

PUSHING FOR CHANGE PM Modi at the Parivartan Mahasabha in Hazaribagh, Oct. 2

ANI

JHARKHAND

Jostling for Tribal Trust

By Amitabh Srivastava

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's intensified focus on Jharkhand, particularly its tribal population, has put adrenaline into the state's electoral landscape. Returning to the state on October 2, just a fortnight after his September 15 show in Jamshedpur, Modi unveiled key initiatives and prophesied the "beginning of change" at a rally in Hazaribagh. The term of the current assembly is set to expire on January 5, and the election has to be completed before then.

Modi opened his 41-minute address with 'Jai Johar', the traditional greeting used by the Santhal community and other Adivasi groups. He emphasised Jharkhand's role in safeguarding the legacy of tribal hero Birsa Munda, weaving local pride into his broader narrative of change and progress. The PM then took aim at his political rivals, accusing the Congress of promoting a single family while erasing the "identity of many tribal families" across India. He highlighted the BJP's Parivartan Yatra, declaring, *"Aaj se Jharkhand mein parivartan ki shuruat ho gayee hai"* (the beginning of change has started in Jharkhand). In a bid to connect with the tribals, he introduced a new slogan: *'Roti, Beti aur Maati'* (bread, daughters and land).

Modi also launched the Dharti Aaba Janjatiya Gram Utkarsh Abhiyan, a flagship initiative with an outlay of over Rs 79,150 crore. Targeted at improving the lives of over 50 million tribal people across India, the programme holds clear electoral weight, especially in a state gearing up for election. Jharkhand, home to a large tribal population, offers a strong base for introducing such a programme, as tribal voters hold considerable influence over electoral outcomes. Of the state's 81 assembly seats, 28 are reserved for Scheduled Tribes (ST), who make up 28 per cent of the population.

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The PM's efforts to engage with the tribal community, along with the BJP's outreach, make good electoral sense in Jharkhand. In 2019, the party lost power to the JMM-Congress-RJD alliance, led by Hemant Soren, partly due to its poor showing in ST-reserved constituencies, where it won just two of the 28 seats. This pattern continued in this year's general election, with the BJP losing all five ST-reserved Lok Sabha seats, despite winning the remaining nine constituencies.

In its big push to win over tribal voters, the BJP is mobilising all available resources to regain lost ground. For instance, Odisha chief minister Mohan Charan Majhi held campaign meetings in West Singhbhum district on September 30, aiming to appeal to Odia-speaking voters across four districts. Simultaneously, senior BJP leaders are highlighting concerns about "Bangladeshi infiltrators" in the Santhal Pargana region, which has 18 ST-reserved seats. The party claims that outsiders are marrying tribal women and taking their jobs and land, aiming to weaken the JMM's traditional support among tribal and minority voters in the area. Prominent BJP leaders, including Union ministers Amit Shah, Rajnath Singh, J.P. Nadda and Shivraj Singh Chouhan (Jharkhand election in-charge), along with CMs Himanta Biswa Sarma, Mohan Yadav, Pushkar Singh Dhami and Majhi, have campaigned across the state during the Parivartan Yatra.

Meanwhile, the JMM has responded with its own campaign, the Maiya Samman Yatra, led by Kalpana Soren, MLA and wife of CM Soren.